conveyed by the defence minister in Parliament. For their conspicuous gallantry and sacrifices, four Param Vir Chakras, nine Mahavir Chakras, fifty-three Vir Chakras and many other gallantry and distinguished services medals were awarded to our officers and men.

- The Air Force lost three officers and two airmen. Flight Lieutenant Nachiketa became a POW as his aircraft crashed after being hit by a stinger missile, and he bailed out and landed on the Pakistani side of the LoC. The air warriors were decorated with two Vir Chakras and twenty-three Vayu Sena Medals besides other distinguished service awards.

When the conflict ended, the DGMO asked me to prepare a historical record of the Kargil war. I formed a team from the MO directorate and made out a broad framework for the task. We asked for the detailed account of operations carried out by all the formations in 15 Corps during Operation Vijay. Once we got these reports, we worked in a time-bound manner and within a few months produced the history of this war. It was printed in-house in the MO directorate and disseminated down to division level. This is perhaps the only war where a history has been written by the MO directorate. It is a voluminous record and has an executive summary and four or five volumes covering all dimensions of the war. Hopefully, someday it would be declassified and available in the public domain. Many officers were decorated amongst our team at the MO directorate. I was awarded an Ati Vishisht Seva Medal and was decorated by the president in 2000.

During my tenure, we were able to get a special allowance sanctioned by the government, named as the highly active field area (HAFA) allowance. There has always been a clamour for an ‘infantry allowance’ to compensate the infantry rank and file for the high percentage of casualties, hardships of service and the separation from their families that they have to endure. Though justifiable, I was sure that this idea would not be acceptable to the officialdom within the army and also in the ministry of defence. On the other hand, it occurred to me that everyone who serves within selected